

Final validation: local photo + video contact-sheet workspace

Research date: August 25, 2026 **Decision:** GO for a small, browser-first MVP; do not pivot to another idea yet.

DECISION

GO: build the combined MVP, but make the reopenable review project the first moat.

Executive answer

Build one product that turns a folder of private photos and video into a reviewable, editable, reopenable contact-sheet project.

The product should not be sold as "another thumbnail grid." The sharper promise is:

Review private media quickly, keep every filename and timestamp attached, and export a clean evidence pack without uploading the files.

The reason to build is not that the market is empty. It is that three facts line up:

- **Photo search demand is the strongest verified acquisition signal available.** The earlier Chrome/Ahrefs session on August 25 showed **contact sheet maker**, **contact sheet photography**, **how to make a contact sheet**, **what is a contact sheet**, and **contact sheet template** above 100 monthly searches in the UK with Easy KD. Those values are session observations, not a current Ahrefs export.
- **Video demand is narrower but more defensible.** The same session showed six UK phrase matches for **video contact sheet** below 100 with KD shown as **N/A**; the U.S. check for **video contact sheet maker** also showed below 100 with KD **N/A**.
- **The build can stay cheap.** Local browser processing, a static site, and client-side exports avoid a database, upload bucket, media-processing bill, and account system.

This is a **build-to-validate** opportunity, not a promise of guaranteed traffic or AdSense income. The recommendation is to ship a focused MVP, measure whether people complete the workflow, and only then add depth.

What we are building

One canonical tool with two clear entry points:

1. **Photo contact sheet:** import a batch of images, sort and arrange them, keep filenames visible, and export a printable PNG, JPG, or PDF.
2. **Video review sheet:** import one or more local videos, sample frames by count or interval, keep source filename and timecode, remove or reorder frames, and export a storyboard plus CSV shot log.

The first version should feel like a lightweight review desk, not a video editor. It should work without an account and should make the privacy boundary obvious: files are decoded in the browser and are not sent to a server.

Final validation

Decision matrix

Direction	Evidence	Competitive reality	Decision
Generic photo-only grid	UK Ahrefs observations show the clearest demand signal; Google autocomplete expands into free, online, Photoshop, Canva, app, photography, and PDF variants.	Basic photo grids are already covered by ContactSheetMaker, Vizua, ImgTweak, Adobe workflows, and other utilities.	Use photo demand for acquisition, but do not stop at a grid.
Video-only contact sheet	Exact video phrases are smaller in the visible Ahrefs checks. Google suggestions still expose a coherent job: generator, storyboard, thumbnail sheet, frame extraction, Mac, Windows, Linux.	Cutsio and TheFluxTrain already claim local processing, timestamps, and storyboard/contact-sheet output. MoviePrint covers a deeper desktop workflow.	Keep video as the wedge, not the whole acquisition plan.
Combined photo + video	One local engine can serve both jobs, while the pages and copy can stay intent-specific.	The combined product is only better if it owns the review, annotation, and handoff workflow.	Recommended.
Pivot to a broader adjacent tool	Broader phrases such as frame extractor and thumbnail maker are plausible, but no fresh numeric volume or difficulty evidence was retrieved for them in this pass.	Those categories already contain multiple free browser tools.	Do not pivot on unmeasured breadth.

Keyword evidence: verified versus directional

Source	What was observed	How to use it
Ahrefs Keyword Generator, UK session observation	contact sheet maker, contact sheet photography, how to make a contact sheet, what is a contact sheet, and contact sheet template showed >100 volume with Easy KD in the supplied session.	Strongest acquisition clue in this research; recheck in a logged-in export before forecasting.
Ahrefs Keyword Generator, UK session observation	Six phrase matches for video contact sheet showed <100 volume and N/A KD: video contact sheet, video contact sheet photoshop, video contact sheet generator, youtube video contact sheet, video contact sheet maker, and video contact sheet windows.	Use for focused landing pages and copy, not as the only traffic source.
Ahrefs Keyword Generator, U.S. session observation	video contact sheet maker showed <100 volume and N/A KD.	Confirms the video-only head term is not enough for an acquisition forecast.
Google Autocomplete, fresh August 25 check	Suggestions consistently expanded the jobs into free, online, Photoshop, Canva, Mac, video contact sheet, video thumbnail sheet, create contact sheet from video, and video shot list template.	Demand-shape and language signal only; autocomplete is not monthly volume.
WordStream	The landing page was opened, but a result table could not be retrieved reliably in the background Chrome session.	No WordStream volume, CPC, or competition number is claimed.

Fresh autocomplete snapshot

This is the successful second keyword-tool check. It tells us how searchers phrase the job; it does not estimate traffic.

Seed	Example suggestions
contact sheet maker	free, online, Photoshop, Canva, online free, app, photography, free download, Mac
photo contact sheet maker	image contact sheet maker, online photo contact sheet creator, how to make a photo contact sheet, how to print contact sheet of photos
video contact sheet maker	video contact sheet maker Mac
video contact sheet generator	online, video contact sheet maker Mac, what is a contact sheet
contact sheet from video	create contact sheet from video, generator from video, contact sheet maker video
video thumbnail sheet	maker, video contact sheet, generator, Mac, online, Linux
video shot log	video footage log, video shoot log, shot list template, shot list example, shot list app
contact sheet PDF	contact sheet PDF, call sheet PDF, call sheet template, call sheet download

Example SERP families

Exact order changes by country, personalization, and time. The following are **sampled result families**, not a claim that every URL ranked in a fixed position.

Query	Result families observed	Gap worth testing
contact sheet maker	ContactSheetMaker, Vizua, ImgTweak, Filmttools-style PDF utilities, tutorials, and design-tool workflows.	Make filename-aware, print-aware, no-upload review faster than a general image utility.
video contact sheet generator	Cutsio, TheFluxTrain, UtilityCove, MoviePrint references, and frame-extraction pages.	Make multi-file review, notes, keep/reject decisions, and reopenable projects first-class.
video frame extractor	TheFluxTrain, generic frame grabbers, converter sites, and tutorial pages.	Do not compete as a one-frame downloader; own the review pack and shot-log outcome.
photo proof sheet with filenames	Contact-sheet utilities, Lightroom/Bridge instructions, and print-layout pages.	Explain the output in the searcher's language: proof sheet, filenames, print, PDF, and client review.

The prior live Google checks hit an unusual-traffic CAPTCHA when testing exact page-2 to page-4 positions. The Reddit page-position heuristic is therefore **not used as proof** of weak competition in this final verdict.

Competitor read

The important update is that "local, private, no signup" is now close to table stakes in this category.

Competitor	Current self-described coverage	What remains open
ContactSheetMaker	Photo contact sheets, flexible grid layouts, filenames, PDF download, saved projects, brand tools, and Ultimate client proofing at \$19/month or \$190/year ; free plan says one sheet each week.	More capable than a one-off utility, but broader SaaS packaging is not the same as a fast local photo-plus-video review desk.
Vizua	Local browser raster sheet for 2-50 JPG/PNG/WebP images, adjustable columns, spacing, background, optional filenames, and a 2400 px canvas.	Photo-only and raster-first; no visible video review or shot-log workflow on the cited page.
ImgTweak	Local photo proof sheet with filenames and numbers, sorting, five sheet sizes including A4 and Letter, no uploads, and no watermark.	Strong photo utility; the opening is a mixed-media review project, not another photo-only page.
MoviePrint	Free desktop software for selecting, analysing, presenting, and archiving movies; shot-based and interval-based MoviePrints, frame selection, scene refinement, and PNG/JSON reimport workflow.	Desktop install and a more specialised interface leave room for a no-install handoff pack.
Cutsio	Free browser storyboard tool that claims local processing, no upload, no signup, no watermark, timestamped JPEG output, and 9/16/25 frame choices.	It proves the video privacy wedge is valuable but not unique; beat it on project continuity, multi-file review, notes, and exports.
TheFluxTrain	Browser frame extractor with exact-frame, multiple-frame, thumbnail-finder, and storyboard modes; claims no signup, no upload, full-resolution output, ZIP download, and timestamped contact sheets.	Avoid competing on extraction alone. Own the review state and structured handoff.
UtilityCove	Local video thumbnail-strip generator with evenly sampled frames, frame-count and column controls, and PNG output.	A deeper review and export workflow is a clear step up from a single strip.
ATELI3R community launch signal	A Reddit launch post describes an offline contact-sheet app with smart SKU filename grouping, batch processing, and multi-sheet output. This is a self-description, not an independent product audit.	Filename intelligence and batch workflows are already appearing; the product must solve the entire review loop, not just add a filename label.

What this means

There is no honest basis for saying the category is uncontested. There is a basis for saying the category is fragmented:

- photo tools are strong at grids, labels, and print output;
- video tools are strong at frame extraction and timestamped storyboards;
- desktop software is strong at shot analysis and archiving;

- hosted products are strong at client proofing and saved workflows.

The opportunity is to join those jobs in a small, private, browser-first workflow with a better handoff artifact.

The moat researcher's recommendation

The moat is a review project, not a privacy slogan

Do not position "we do not upload your files" as the moat. Cutsio, TheFluxTrain, Vizua, ImgTweak, and UtilityCove already make similar claims. Privacy is a trust requirement and a conversion advantage; it is not enough by itself to keep competitors out.

The recommended moat is a **Reopenable Review Project**: a local, portable project that remembers the user's source files, sampling settings, chosen frames, annotations, and export preferences.

The user should be able to complete this loop:

1. **Ingest**: choose a folder or mixed batch of photos and videos.
2. **Sample**: choose fixed count, interval, exact timecode, or photo order.
3. **Review**: move through frames with keyboard shortcuts; keep, reject, flag, or note each item.
4. **Organise**: preserve source filename, dimensions, duration, timecode, frame number, and optional file hash.
5. **Export**: create a print-ready sheet, a CSV/TSV shot log, a JSON project manifest, and an optional ZIP of selected frames.
6. **Reopen**: load the project later, relink the local files if necessary, and continue without starting from zero.

That turns a one-off generator into a repeat-use tool. It also creates a useful artifact that is harder to replace than a PNG thumbnail strip.

Moat stack

Layer	What to ship	Why it compounds	Cost fit
Workflow depth	Multi-file review with keep/reject/flag, notes, keyboard controls, and source-aware ordering.	Users return because their decision process lives in the tool, not only in the export.	Client-side only.
Portable project format	Export and reopen a small <code>.contactsheet.json</code> manifest; optionally pair it with a self-contained HTML review pack.	Creates a habit and a durable handoff format without a server account.	Client-side only.
Structured handoff	Stable CSV/TSV columns for source, timecode, frame, status, notes, tags, and dimensions.	Makes the output useful in spreadsheets and production handoffs; templates can improve over time.	Client-side only.
Repeatable presets	Save local presets for portrait proof sheets, landscape storyboards, A4, Letter, 16:9, and thumbnail-candidate review.	Users can recreate a familiar output in seconds.	Local storage or IndexedDB.
Privacy proof	Static privacy page, visible network behavior, no filename analytics, and a "works offline after load" test.	Converts a claim into something a cautious user can verify.	No backend required.
Distribution loop	Publish useful templates, sample CSVs, format guides, and comparison pages tied to real outputs.	Builds links and search coverage around jobs, not thin synonyms.	Static content.
Optional local AI	On-device labels or a handoff summary only after the core workflow is reliable.	Adds convenience without creating an API bill or default upload risk.	Progressive enhancement.

What not to count as a moat

- A generic grid with a different color palette.

- "No signup" alone.
- "No upload" alone.
- A single exact-timestamp frame capture.
- A large list of file-extension landing pages.
- A free cloud AI quota.
- A client-proofing backend that violates the domain-only budget.

Prioritised feature list

P0: the smallest useful wedge

1. Drag-and-drop mixed photo and video input.
2. Local-only processing with an explicit privacy explanation.
3. Photo grid mode with filenames, dimensions, sorting, and print presets.
4. Video fixed-count and interval sampling with visible timecodes.
5. Keep, reject, remove, and reorder controls.
6. Keyboard shortcuts for next, previous, keep, reject, and export.
7. PNG/JPG export and a print-oriented PDF.
8. CSV/TSV shot-log export for video.
9. JSON project-manifest export and reopen.
10. Clear errors for unsupported codecs, large files, and browser limits.

P1: turn it into a repeat workflow

- Multi-file video batches with source grouping.
- Per-frame notes, tags, and status filters.
- A self-contained HTML review pack that includes the sheet and metadata.
- A4, Letter, 16:9, portrait, landscape, and contact-proof presets.
- Exact timestamp capture and near-frame stepping.

P2: only after usage proves demand

- Scene-boundary suggestions.
- Duplicate or near-duplicate suppression.
- Optional local AI labels and handoff summaries.
- A lightweight plugin or export schema for editing workflows.
- Cloud sharing or client proofing; this is deliberately outside the first budget.

SEO and information architecture

Use one product and separate pages for distinct intent. Do not create a page for every synonym.

Pages

- [/contact-sheet-maker/](#) - canonical combined tool; explain photo sheets and video storyboards.

- /photo-contact-sheet-maker/ - photo batches, filenames, print layouts, PDF, proof sheets.
- /video-contact-sheet-maker/ - video frames, timestamps, storyboard, shot log.
- /contact-sheet-from-video/ - only if the page has a materially different workflow and explanation.
- /video-frame-extractor/ - later supporting page; do not let it become the product promise.

Keyword lists to run in Ahrefs

These are seed lists, not volume claims. Recheck them for the U.S., U.K., Canada, Australia, New Zealand, Germany, Switzerland, Norway, Denmark, and the UAE before using them for a forecast.

Acquisition and photo terms

- contact sheet maker
- free contact sheet maker
- contact sheet generator online
- photo contact sheet maker free
- contact sheet PDF
- photo proof sheet with filenames
- how to make a contact sheet
- contact sheet template

Video workflow terms

- video contact sheet maker
- video contact sheet generator
- video contact sheet online
- contact sheet from video
- create contact sheet from video
- video storyboard generator
- timestamped video storyboard
- video shot log
- video footage logging tool

Long-tail and problem phrasing

- make a thumbnail sheet from a video
- see all video frames at once
- review video footage quickly
- extract frames from MP4 without uploading
- extract frames from MOV online
- video contact sheet without uploading
- contact sheet from folder images
- select a YouTube thumbnail from a video
- how to create a shot log from rushes

- photo contact sheet for client review

Comparison terms

- MoviePrint alternative
- MoviePrint online alternative
- video contact sheet app alternative
- best video contact sheet generator
- video storyboard generator free vs paid
- contact sheet maker Photoshop alternative

Content that supports the tool

Start with pages that produce a real asset or answer a distinct job:

1. How to make a contact sheet from photos.
2. How to make a contact sheet from a video.
3. Photo contact sheet versus video storyboard.
4. How to extract frames from MP4 without uploading it.
5. How to create a shot log from rushes.
6. MoviePrint alternatives: desktop versus browser workflows.
7. Contact sheet templates for A4, Letter, portrait, and 16:9 review.

The best linkable assets are a free shot-log CSV template, a printable storyboard template, and a real explanation of the portable project format.

Product economics and launch constraints

The first release fits the domain-only constraint if it stays client-side:

- static HTML/CSS/JavaScript;
- browser video decoding and Canvas/WebCodecs where available;
- Web Workers for long extraction jobs;
- local memory, IndexedDB, or the Origin Private File System for project state;
- client-side image, PDF, CSV, JSON, and ZIP exports;
- GitHub Pages or Cloudflare Pages for static delivery.

GitHub Pages documents static site publishing; Cloudflare documents a free Pages plan. Verify the current limits at launch because hosting terms can change. The point is not "zero maintenance"; browser compatibility, codec support, and content updates still require care.

For AdSense, place inventory on guides, templates, and comparisons rather than beside the file drop zone or during export. The tool's first job is trust and activation.

Risks and validation gates

Risk	Gate before expanding
Browser codec and large-file failures	Test MP4, MOV, and WebM samples on Chrome and Firefox; show a graceful fallback message.
Users only want one quick PNG	Track whether users use notes, ordering, CSV, or reopen; keep the moat only if people touch it.
Photo traffic but weak video usage	Keep the combined product; improve the video page and onboarding rather than pivoting blindly.
Privacy claim is not trusted	Verify network behavior with devtools and publish exactly what leaves the device.
SEO signal is too small	Re-run the complete seed set in logged-in Ahrefs for the ten target countries before building a content backlog.
AdSense harms the tool	Delay ads on the core workspace until activation and export work cleanly.

Four-week build-to-validate plan

Week 1 - prove decoding: local image import, one video, fixed interval frames, timestamps, basic grid. **Week 2 - prove the handoff:** keep/reject, ordering, PNG/JPG/PDF, CSV shot log. **Week 3 - prove repeat use:** JSON manifest, reopen/relink, presets, large-file errors, offline refresh. **Week 4 - prove demand:** publish the photo and video pages, recruit 5-10 real editors/creators, observe successful exports and repeat sessions, and only then decide whether P1 is justified.

The target is not a vanity sign-up count. The useful signal is a successful export from a real local file, followed by either a second project or a request for a missing workflow feature.

Final recommendation

GO - build the combined photo-plus-video MVP now, but build the review-project moat from the first usable version.

Lead SEO with the broader photo contact-sheet demand. Lead product differentiation with video timestamps, multi-file review, structured shot logs, and a portable project manifest. Treat local processing as a trust requirement, not the moat. Do not spend time on AI, cloud proofing, or a higher-volume pivot until real users prove that the review loop is worth repeating.

This is worth building as a low-cost, testable utility. It is not yet justified as a large platform or a guaranteed AdSense winner.

Research notes and references

Evidence standard. Competitor feature and pricing statements below are based on the cited pages' own descriptions captured on August 25, 2026. A competitor not mentioning a feature is not proof that it lacks the feature elsewhere. Ahrefs values are prior visible Chrome-session observations from this project, not a downloadable export. No RPM ranking, revenue forecast, or traffic forecast is included.

1. Ahrefs Free Keyword Generator - <https://ahrefs.com/keyword-generator>
2. WordStream Free Keyword Tool - <https://www.wordstream.com/keywords>
3. Google Autocomplete endpoint used for suggestion checks - <https://suggestqueries.google.com/complete/search>
4. ContactSheetMaker - <https://www.contactsheetmaker.com/>
5. Vizua Contact Sheet - <https://vizua.io/contact-sheet/>
6. ImgTweak Contact Sheet Generator - <https://imgtweak.com/contact-sheet-generator>
7. MoviePrint - <https://www.movieprint.org/>
8. Cutsio Storyboard Generator - <https://cutsio.com/storyboard-generator>
9. TheFluxTrain Video Frame Extractor - <https://thefluxtrain.com/tools/video-frame-extractor/>
10. UtilityCove Video Thumbnail Strip Generator - <https://utilitycove.org/video/video-thumbnail-strip-generator.html>
11. ATFLI3R community launch post - <https://www.reddit.com/r/VideoEditors/comments/1m5s5ag/>
12. MDN File System API - https://developer.mozilla.org/en-US/docs/Web/API/File_System_API

13. MDN WebCodecs API - https://developer.mozilla.org/en-US/docs/Web/API/WebCodecs_API
14. GitHub Pages documentation - <https://docs.github.com/en/pages/getting-started-with-github-pages/what-is-github-pages>
15. Cloudflare Pages limits - <https://developers.cloudflare.com/pages/platform/limits/>
16. WebLLM local inference documentation - <https://webllm.io/docs/guides/local-inference/>
17. Reddit photography contact-sheet discussion - <https://www.reddit.com/r/photography/comments/r7xp2d/>
18. Reddit photography contact-sheet generator discussion - <https://www.reddit.com/r/photography/comments/1l1koy2/>
19. Reddit video contact-sheet discussion - <https://www.reddit.com/r/VideoEditing/comments/1pcvky5/>
20. Reddit video thumbnail/contact-sheet discussion - <https://www.reddit.com/r/VideoEditing/comments/1d1v4a8/>